

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath visit the Space Museum developed under the Smart City Mission in Jhansi.

Bundelkhand's Transformation: From Drought to Development

Once synonymous with drought, migration, unemployment, and underdevelopment, Bundelkhand has witnessed a remarkable transformation in recent years. The initiatives launched by the double-engine government under Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath to bring the region into the mainstream of development are now yielding visible results on the ground. From addressing water scarcity and attracting industrial investment to promoting natural farming, branding agricultural products, and developing the Defence Corridor, Bundelkhand is today writing several new chapters of growth and progress. The government's strategy extends beyond providing basic amenities; it aims to transform Bundelkhand into a self-reliant region and a strong hub of employment generation. This is one of the key reasons why the region is increasingly emerging as a preferred destination for investors.

Industrialisation is widely regarded as the cornerstone of Bundelkhand's development. With this vision, the Bundelkhand Industrial Development Authority (BIDA) is being expanded at a rapid pace. The government has approved 56,662 acres of land for industrial development, while the acquisition process for an additional 23,590 acres has been accelerated. BIDA is being developed not merely as an industrial zone but as an integrated economic hub. Modern infrastructure is being created to support heavy industries, defence manufacturing, MSMEs, logistics, and ancillary units. Special emphasis is being placed on roads, power supply, water infrastructure, warehousing, and seamless connectivity to create an investor-friendly ecosystem. In this direction, the proposed investment of nearly ₹600 crore by Bharat Earth Movers Limited (BEML) is considered particularly significant. The investment will facilitate the establishment of manufacturing units for heavy machinery and defence equipment, creating substantial employment opportunities at the local level.

Defence Corridor emerges as a growth driver

Bundelkhand is poised to be among the biggest beneficiaries of the Uttar Pradesh Defence Industrial Corridor. The Jhansi and Chitrakoot nodes have emerged as preferred destinations for investors. In Jhansi, Goodluck Astra has proposed an investment of nearly ₹1,000 crore on 247 acres of land, while Redwood Hughes has submitted an investment proposal worth ₹700 crore. In addition, companies such as Citadel and Gurutva are preparing to invest in the defence and allied manufacturing sectors. In Chitrakoot, Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL) has proposed an investment of ₹672 crore. Meanwhile, IG Drones plans to invest ₹100 crore in the drone technology sector. Through these projects, efforts are being made to develop Bundelkhand into a major hub for defence manufacturing, electronics, and drone technology. Experts believe that the Defence Corridor will not only attract investments but will also create opportunities for skill development, technical training, and high-quality employment. A robust logistics network is essential for sustained industrial growth. Keeping this in view, a state-of-the-art Multi-Modal Logistics Park is being developed on 100 acres of land within the BIDA region. The park, to be developed by the Container Corporation of India (CONCOR), will seamlessly integrate road and rail transport. This will reduce freight costs, enhance industrial competitiveness, and provide a significant boost to exports.

Water reaches every household

For decades, Bundelkhand was synonymous with water scarcity. Dry hand pumps during summer, empty ponds, and the daily struggle for water had become defining images of the region. However, this narrative has changed rapidly under the Jal Jeevan Mission. According to current figures, more than 98 per cent of rural households across all seven districts of Bundelkhand now have access to tap water connections. In several districts, the coverage has crossed 99 per cent. Districts such as Banda, Chitrakoot, Mahoba, Hamirpur, and Lalitpur have achieved near-universal access to piped drinking water. Across the entire Bundelkhand region, approximately 99.79 per cent of rural households have been provided Functional Household Tap Connections (FHTCs). This transformation extends far beyond statistics. Rural women are no longer compelled to travel several kilometres to fetch water. The availability of tap water has led to significant savings in time, improved health outcomes, and increased participation of families in social and economic activities.

Natural farming gains ground

Agriculture has always been challenging in Bundelkhand due to water scarcity and limited natural resources. However, natural farming is